TOPIC 02 · SKILLS AND RULES
LAB 6 THEME · CUSTOM SKILLS: CALENDAR

Lab 6 — Use Copilot to Build a Custom Interview-Calendar Skill

Maps to	LO2: use Copilot to write a custom SKILL.md, save it in the OneDrive skills folder, call it with @, and improve it so a weekly task runs from a one-line prompt
Duration	45 minutes
Tools	Excel · Copilot (Chat only, Allow editing) · Manage plugins & skills · OneDrive skills folder · SKILL.md
Mock data	data/BrightPath_Interview_Schedule.xlsx
Lab files	skills/interview-calendar/SKILL.md (ready-made skill to upload if you run short of time)
Course	Microsoft 365 Copilot for Excel (C34) · v3.1
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-6

Goal

Create an interview-calendar skill that turns BrightPath's interview list into a weekly calendar with clashes flagged - and reuse it for the next week with one short prompt.

What You Will Do

Every Friday a BrightPath coordinator turns next week's interview bookings into a calendar and hunts for double-bookings. That is a repeatable recipe, so it should be a skill. You will open the sample calendar skill in your OneDrive skills folder, ask Copilot to write a new SKILL.md for interview-calendar, save it in its own folder, refresh the skills list and call it with @. The same one-line prompt then builds the next week's calendar.

What You Will Build

An interview-calendar skill in your OneDrive skills folder, and BrightPath_Interview_Schedule.xlsx with Cal_2026-07-06 and Cal_2026-07-13 calendar sheets, each with clashes flagged and a summary

Prerequisites

- Lab 5 completed: you can find, enable and @mention skills.
- Access to your OneDrive in a browser (custom skills are stored in a OneDrive folder).
- This lab folder's data workbook and skills/interview-calendar/SKILL.md (fallback).

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional BrightPath data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real employees' personal data into Copilot, rules or skills.

Steps

Step 1. Copy BrightPath_Interview_Schedule.xlsx from this lab's data folder into a work-c34 folder on your computer and open it in Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop). Work on this local copy - no OneDrive upload is needed. Check that Formulas > Calculation Options is Automatic, then open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab or the floating Copilot icon at the bottom right. Read the About_This_Data sheet before you prompt. The workbook stays local; only the skill file goes in OneDrive (Step 2).

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Table : tblInterviews (41 interviews, 6-17 July 2026)
Week 1 : Mon 6 July - Fri 10 July 2026
Week 2 : Mon 13 July - Fri 17 July 2026
Clash : same Interviewer overlapping, or two Onsite interviews in the same Room overlapping
```

Step 2. Create your skills folder. In the Copilot pane select Settings (...) > Manage plugins & skills > Custom skills and turn the Custom skills switch on. Then select Add in OneDrive (in some versions: Create OneDrive folder, then Open skills folder). OneDrive opens a folder named skills, usually under Documents > Copilot > Microsoft Excel. Open the sample calendar skill folder (e.g. make-calendar.example) and read its SKILL.md: a front matter block between --- lines, then plain-English steps.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Folder : skills/<skill-name>/ (folder name = the skill name, lower case with hyphens)
File : SKILL.md
Front matter: name (the skill name) and description (when Copilot should use it)
Body : the steps Copilot follows - plain English, no code needed
```

Step 3. Let Copilot write the skill. In Excel, choose Chat only and send the prompt below. Read the reply: it should start with --- name: interview-calendar, have a description that says when to use it, and list clear steps. Ask for changes until you are happy.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
Write a Copilot in Excel custom skill as a complete SKILL.md file.
Name: interview-calendar
Description: Use when I ask for an interview calendar, schedule or clashes for a week.
The skill must:
1) Read tblInterviews (Interview_ID, Role, Interviewer, Interview_Date, Start_Time,
Duration_Min, Mode, Room).
2) Ask for the week start date (a Monday) if I do not give one.
3) Create a sheet Cal_<yyyy-mm-dd> with Monday to Friday as columns and 30-minute rows from
09:00 to 17:30.
4) In each slot show Interviewer - Role (Mode); colour Onsite light blue and Video light
green.
5) Flag clashes: overlapping interviews with the same Interviewer, or Onsite interviews in the
same Room.
   Colour them red and list them in a Clashes table under the calendar.
6) Add a summary of interviews per day and per Interviewer.
7) Never change tblInterviews.
Return only the SKILL.md text, starting with the --- front matter.
```

Step 4. Save the skill. Copy Copilot's reply into a plain-text editor (Notepad, or TextEdit in plain-text mode) and save it as SKILL.md. In the OneDrive skills folder select New > Folder, name it interview-calendar, open it and Upload SKILL.md. Short of time? Upload skills/interview-calendar/SKILL.md from this lab folder instead.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
OneDrive : .../skills/interview-calendar/SKILL.md
Check : the folder name and the name: line are both exactly interview-calendar
Check : the file is called SKILL.md (not SKILL.md.txt)
```

Step 5. Make Excel see the new skill: Settings (...) > Manage plugins & skills > Custom skills, check the Custom skills switch is on and select Refresh (the round arrow). Wait until the list loads, then turn interview-calendar on. Close the dialog and type @inter in the prompt box - the skill should appear.

Step 6. Run the skill in Allow editing with a one-line prompt. First check that the title bar shows BrightPath_Interview_Schedule: the skill is available in every workbook, but it only works where tblInterviews exists. When it finishes, inspect the calendar and select Done. Then ask Copilot to add the check formula and compare it with the number of interviews on the calendar.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@interview-calendar Build the calendar for the week starting Monday 6 July 2026.

CHECK (Allow editing):
In an empty cell to the right of the calendar, add this formula and tell me whether it matches the number of interviews on the calendar:
=COUNTIFS(tblInterviews[Interview_Date],">="&DATE(2026,7,6),tblInterviews[Interview_Date],"<="&DATE(2026,7,10))
```

Step 7. Reuse it. This is the point of a skill: next week's calendar needs only the skill name and a date. Week 2 has no clashes - check the skill says so.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@interview-calendar Week starting 13 July 2026.
```

Step 8. Improve the skill. Ask Copilot to update the file, save it over SKILL.md in OneDrive, select Refresh in Custom skills and rerun week 1. A skill is a living recipe: improve it whenever you correct Copilot twice. Log your prompts.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHAT ONLY:
Update the interview-calendar SKILL.md so the summary also shows total interview hours per Interviewer, and the reply lists the busiest day. Return the full updated file.

LOG (Allow editing):
Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab. For each one I ran, fill in What Copilot did and How I verified, and set Decision to Keep. I will tell you any row to change to Revise or Undo.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Copilot pane (or adapt them). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online:
https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-6

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Write a skill	Write a SKILL.md for a skill named weekly-recruiter-report that summarises interviews by Interviewer and Client for a given week, with a small bar chart.
2	Explain a skill	Read this SKILL.md and tell me what Copilot will do, step by step, and anything that is unclear.
3	Call a skill	@interview-calendar Build the calendar for the week starting Monday 6 July 2026.
4	Reuse	@interview-calendar Week starting 13 July 2026.
5	Clash check	List every interview clash in tblInterviews for 6-10 July 2026 with both Interview_IDs.
6	Improve	Update the skill so Video interviews show the Teams icon text [Teams] and the calendar prints on one A4 page.
7	Question	Which interviewer has the most interviews in the week of 6 July, and on which day?

Test It

Check	Expected result
Week of 6 July	23 interviews = the COUNTIFS check
By day	Mon 7, Tue 5, Wed 5, Thu 3, Fri 3
Clashes flagged	INT-010/INT-011 Kevin Ong; INT-015/INT-016 Orchid Room; INT-018/INT-019 Aisha Rahman
Busiest interviewer	Aisha Rahman (9 interviews)
Week of 13 July	18 interviews, no clashes
Skill	interview-calendar appears when you type @ and runs from a one-line prompt

Checkpoint

Keep the skill: it stays in your OneDrive and works in any workbook with an interviews table. Topic 3 uses rules and skills to build dashboards.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
The skill does not appear after Refresh.	The folder name must match the name: line exactly (lower case, hyphens) and the file must be SKILL.md inside that folder. Select Refresh again.
There is no Add in OneDrive or Create OneDrive folder button.	Custom skills are rolling out and depend on your licence and update channel. Use the ready-made SKILL.md to read the format, and run the same steps as a normal prompt instead.
Copilot says tblInterviews is not present in this workbook.	The skill ran in another lab's workbook. Open BrightPath_Interview_Schedule.xlsx and send the prompt again from its Copilot pane.
The calendar misses a clash.	Ask: 'Check again for overlapping interviews with the same Interviewer or the same Onsite Room on each day.' Then add that wording to the skill's steps.
The file saved as SKILL.md.txt or with formatting.	Save as plain text with the exact name SKILL.md. In TextEdit choose Format > Make Plain Text first.

Challenge

Ask Copilot to write a second skill, weekly-recruiter-report, that summarises interviews by Interviewer and Client for a given week with a small bar chart. Save it, refresh and call it.

Reflection

Which weekly or monthly task in your own job would make the best first custom skill, and what would its description say?